Eastern Europe. The war in Ukraine has further revived interest in this part of the Continent.

Much of what is contained in the following pages was published in 2009 under the title *What's So Eastern About Eastern Europe?* The aim of the book then was to familiarise the reader with basic political and social history of the region. A lot of that has, as I said, now became a part of general knowledge and does not need to be repeated. But since then there have also been new developments that have puzzled Western audiences again and posed, albeit in a different way, the same question again: what is so different, after all, about Eastern Europe that, after successfully becoming a part of Europe again, it seems to have turned into what has become known as 'Illiberal Europe'? This is, at least, how it looks. This question calls for a new, revised and updated edition that retains most of the historical account of the first edition, but omits some of the now less relevant facts, and rather focuses on those aspects that put the so-called illiberal drift or democratic backslide into contemporary perspective.

The book concludes with a final chapter (and an epilogue) explaining the nature of and reasons for this backlash, and putting it into the context of the crisis of liberal democracy, as experienced in the global West today. And it is in this crisis too that – while certainly possessing its own specific problems – Central Europe remains very much a part of Europe and the global West, including when it comes to the current culture wars in the West. In fact, while this book is essentially about Eastern Europe, its political and cultural history, before and after the fall of the Berlin Wall, it also shows that the current challenges to the liberal order in this part of Europe are to a great extent an offshoot of the same trends in the West – and of its insecurity about itself in a dangerous time. What we are witnessing is not only about the choice between liberal and illiberal, but also between different interpretations of a liberal order. In this analysis of illiberal Europe, as well as in the search for a genuine and noble Western liberalism and a true and distinct European identity, Eastern Europe is therefore only a convenient geographic point of departure. More than just a question of geography, illiberal Europe is a state of mind worthy of exploration.

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1. https://www.independent.co.uk/news/obituaries/karl-lavrencic-36832.html (Retrieved on 23 June 2022.)